common drinking water tap they used. But his fierce intelligence earned him scholarships that took him first to Bombay (now Mumbai), then to Columbia University in New York and finally to the London School of Economics. By the time he returned to India for good in 1923, he was one of the best educated men in the country. Yet, no matter how well-educated or well-dressed he became, Ambedkar continued to be viciously discriminated against by his countrymen.

Separate electorates were introduced by the British, supposedly as a way to ensure that minorities (like Muslims) would be fairly represented in government. A certain number of seats were reserved for minority candidates, and only voters belonging to those communities were allowed to vote for them.

Fighting against the caste system

Ambedkar would wage a lifelong battle against caste-based and gender-based prejudice. He was outspoken and uncompromising in calling out injustice and saw the caste system as an entrenched evil that needed to be destroyed. He also believed that the ‘Depressed Classes’ (the term used then; the preferred term today is Dalit) had to fight for their own rights rather than rely on upper-caste Hindus to initiate reforms. He established several organizations, began his own political parties, and led campaigns to educate Dalits about their rights. He also tried to work with the British to secure political representation for the ‘lower’ castes. When Gandhi and the Congress did not agree to his demand for separate electorates for Dalits, Ambedkar began to doubt the upper-caste dominated Congress’s commitment to fighting caste prejudice.

Framing the Constitution

Ambedkar believed that the law and government would play an important role in reforming society and that a country could only progress